ACT / READING / FREE GUIDE

ACT Reading Strategy Guide

Read for structure, locate the proof, and keep your pace under control.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Build a quick passage map

Notice who or what the passage is about, how each paragraph contributes, and where the author changes direction. A mental label such as problem, example, or objection helps you relocate information without memorizing every detail.

Distinguish detail from interpretation

For a direct detail, locate the relevant sentence and paraphrase it accurately. For an inference, combine only what the passage supports. For tone, look at the author’s word choices rather than your own reaction to the topic.

Handle broad questions after understanding structure

A main-idea answer should cover the passage’s central focus without exaggerating it. A title-like phrase may be too vague. A highly specific answer may describe just one paragraph. Check both scope and accuracy.

Keep a purposeful pace

Practice with official materials matching your administration’s format. When two choices remain, identify the precise difference and look for evidence that settles it. If the evidence is not clear and time is limited, choose your best answer and move forward.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

Question type	Best next step	Avoid
Detail	Return to the relevant lines	Relying on a fuzzy memory
Main idea	Summarize all major parts	Picking an isolated example
Tone	Look for evaluative language	Projecting your opinion
Inference	Trace a small logical step	Making a broad prediction

Original worked example

Original passage: “Nora expected the archive to be silent. Instead, volunteers debated dates, compared letters, and asked her to join them. By closing time, she had signed up for another shift.” How does Nora’s experience change?

She moves from expecting a quiet setting to participating in an active, collaborative one. Signing up again supports interest in returning; it does not establish that she has chosen a career.

A tip worth keeping

Leave a short mental label for each paragraph. This saves time when a question sends you back to a detail.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. What detail supports Nora’s interest in returning?

2. Can we infer that Nora dislikes quiet places?

3. Which better describes the archive: collaborative or deserted?

Answers & explanations

1. She signed up for another shift.

2. No. Her expectation does not establish a general preference.

3. Collaborative. Volunteers discuss information and invite Nora to participate.

Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

Official ACT format updates

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